
Pharma Compliance Readiness Checklist

A practical self-check for pharmaceutical and biotech companies: is your compliance programme working day to day, and would the evidence stand up to an audit or inspection?

For: Compliance leads, medical affairs and leadership teams at emerging biotech and small to mid-sized pharma.

Governance and ownership

- ☐ A named senior owner is accountable for compliance, with authority to escalate.
- ☐ Compliance roles, decision rights and escalation routes are documented.
- ☐ Compliance matters are reported to leadership through a regular governance forum.

Policies and SOPs

- ☐ Core policies exist for promotion and materials review, HCP and HCO engagement, patient organisations, grants and donations, anti-bribery and anti-corruption, and conflicts of interest.
- ☐ SOPs are mapped to how teams actually work, not only to the code.
- ☐ Policies have owners and a defined review cycle.

Risk assessment

- ☐ A documented compliance risk assessment covers your highest-risk activities, such as HCP engagements, materials review, transparency and third parties.
- ☐ The assessment is refreshed when the business changes, not only annually.
- ☐ Monitoring and training plans are driven by the assessed risks.

HCP engagement and fair market value

- ☐ Each engagement has a documented legitimate need and objective selection criteria.
- ☐ Written contracts are signed before services start.
- ☐ Fees follow a documented fair market value methodology with tiering criteria.

Materials review and approval

- ☐ A defined review workflow with qualified reviewers and certifying signatories.
- ☐ Every approved item has a retrievable audit trail.
- ☐ Turnaround and review cycles are measured.

Transparency and disclosure

- ☐ Transfers of value are captured when the engagement is planned, not at year end.
- ☐ Classification rules are documented and applied consistently.
- ☐ Country-specific disclosure requirements are mapped and reconciled before submission.

Third parties

- ☐ Distributors, agencies and vendors are risk-rated and subject to proportionate due diligence.
- ☐ Contracts include compliance, audit and termination clauses.
- ☐ Higher-risk third parties are monitored after onboarding.

Training and culture

- ☐ Training is role-based and scenario-based, not a one-off e-learning.
- ☐ Training effectiveness is measured.
- ☐ People know how to raise concerns, and concerns are followed up.

Monitoring, audit and CAPA

- ☐ A risk-based monitoring plan is in place and followed.
- ☐ Internal audits test how controls operate, not only whether documents exist.
- ☐ Findings have root causes, owners, due dates and effectiveness checks.

Markets, data and technology

- ☐ Local codes, laws and any legal representative roles are mapped for each country you operate in.
- ☐ Compliance records and evidence can be retrieved quickly for an audit.
- ☐ Any AI use in compliance processes is assessed, documented and subject to human oversight.

This checklist is a practical guide, not legal advice. Requirements depend on your markets, activities and the codes that apply to you.